

Brand & Style Guide

Client Lead Management System (Mini CRM)

How to use this document

This is not a mood board. It is a specification. Every value here is final and must be used literally. When generating UI — by hand or with AI — reference this document for every colour, size, spacing, and component decision. Do not improvise.

If a design decision is not covered here, add a rule to this document before implementing it. The point is to have one place that decides, so nothing defaults to generic.

1. Design Principles

Five principles govern every decision. When two options conflict, the earlier principle wins.

1. Calm by default. The interface is a workspace, not a landing page. Most of the screen is neutral. Colour and emphasis are reserved for information that actually needs attention — a lead due today, an error, a primary action. If everything is emphasised, nothing is.

2. Data over decoration. The lead list is the product. Every pixel spent on ornament is a pixel not spent on legibility. Assume the user is on a phone, in a hurry, glancing at the screen between other tasks. Optimise for that.

3. One accent, used sparingly. There is exactly one accent colour (deep blue). It appears on primary buttons, active navigation, focus rings, and links. It does not appear in backgrounds, gradients, illustrations, or decoration. The constraint is the point.

4. Borders before shadows. Structure is expressed through 1px borders, not drop shadows. Cards have no shadow. Only overlays — modals, dropdowns, popovers, toasts — cast shadows, because they genuinely float above the page. This single rule does more to prevent a "generated" look than any other.

5. Legibility is non-negotiable. Minimum 13px for any text, minimum 44px touch targets, WCAG AA contrast everywhere, no exceptions for aesthetics.

2. Anti-Patterns

These are prohibited. They are the default outputs of AI design tools and generic component libraries, and they are what this document exists to prevent.

Never do these

- **No gradients.** Not on backgrounds, buttons, text, borders, or icons. Solid fills only.
- **No glassmorphism.** No `backdrop-filter: blur`, no frosted panels, no translucent cards.
- **No purple.** Not in the palette, not as an accent, not anywhere. Purple-to-pink gradients are the single most recognisable tell of AI-generated UI.
- **No blurred background shapes.** No "orbs", "blobs", "glows", or abstract gradient meshes behind content.
- **No emoji as UI.** No emoji in headings, buttons, labels, empty states, or navigation. Icons only, from the approved set.
- **No stock illustrations.** No abstract figures, no "undraw"-style characters, no isometric drawings.
- **No shadows on cards, inputs, or buttons.** The only elements that cast shadows are modals, dropdowns, popovers, and toasts.
- **No border-radius above 12px** on any rectangular container. Pills and avatars are the only fully-round elements.
- **No animated backgrounds or looping motion.** Nothing moves unless the user caused it.
- **No bouncy or springy easing.** Motion is linear or standard ease. No overshoot, no wobble.
- **No gradient text.** Ever.
- **No hero sections.** The dashboard is a workspace, not a marketing page. There is no large centred headline with two buttons and an illustration.
- **No decorative icons.** Icons appear next to a label or inside a button with text. Never floating, never oversized, never coloured for decoration.
- **No "Get Started" copy.** Buttons say what they do: "Add lead", "Save changes", "Delete lead".
- **No alternating row colours** in tables. Use hover state and row separators. Not both plus zebra striping.
- **No modals with centred text and generous padding.** Forms in modals are left-aligned, compact, and dense.
- **No placeholder text as label.** Every input has a visible `<label>` above it. Placeholder shows an example value, not the field name.
- **No multiple font weights on one screen** beyond regular, medium, and semibold. No 100-weight, no 900-weight.
- **No font sizes below 12px.**
- **No full-page loading spinners.** Use skeletons that match the eventual layout.

Why this list exists

The failure mode is not ugliness — it is sameness. Every AI-generated admin panel in 2026 looks like every other: soft purple gradient header, frosted glass cards with big shadows, generous whitespace, and a sparkles icon. That look signals "generated" to anyone who reviews software for a living. Restraint reads as authorship.

3. Colour Tokens

All colours are defined as tokens. Use the token name in code, never the raw hex. Names are semantic, so a token can be retargeted without touching components.

3.1 Light theme

Token	Hex	Usage
bg-canvas	#FAFAFA	Page background
bg-surface	#FFFFFF	Cards, inputs, table background
bg-subtle	#F4F4F5	Hover states, secondary buttons, code blocks
bg-muted	#E4E4E7	Pressed states, selected table row
border-default	#E4E4E7	All standard borders, table dividers
border-strong	#A1A1AA	Input focus alternative, emphasised dividers
text-primary	#18181B	Body text, headings
text-secondary	#52525B	Metadata, helper text, labels
text-tertiary	#71717A	Placeholder, disabled text
accent	#1D4ED8	Primary buttons, links, focus ring, active nav
accent-hover	#1E40AF	Primary button hover
accent-subtle-bg	#EFF6FF	Selected nav, subtle accent backgrounds
success	#15803D	Converted status, success toasts

Token	Hex	Usage
success-subtle-bg	#F0FDF4	Converted badge background
warning	#B45309	Contacted status, due-soon emphasis
warning-subtle-bg	#FFFBEB	Contacted badge background
danger	#B91C1C	Delete actions, errors, overdue emphasis
danger-subtle-bg	#FEF2F2	Lost badge background, error backgrounds
neutral-subtle-bg	#F4F4F5	New badge background, inactive states

3.2 Dark theme

Token	Hex	Usage
bg-canvas	#09090B	Page background
bg-surface	#18181B	Cards, inputs
bg-subtle	#27272A	Hover states, secondary buttons
bg-muted	#3F3F46	Pressed, selected
border-default	#27272A	Standard borders
border-strong	#52525B	Focus alternative
text-primary	#FAFAFA	Body text
text-secondary	#A1A1AA	Metadata
text-tertiary	#71717A	Placeholder
accent	#3B82F6	Primary buttons, links, focus
accent-hover	#60A5FA	Hover
accent-subtle-bg	#1E3A8A @ 30%	Selected nav

Token	Hex	Usage
success	#4ADE80	Converted
success-subtle-bg	#14532D @ 30%	Converted badge
warning	#FBBF24	Contacted
warning-subtle-bg	#78350F @ 30%	Contacted badge
danger	#F87171	Errors, delete
danger-subtle-bg	#7F1D1D @ 30%	Error background
neutral-subtle-bg	#27272A	New badge

3.3 Status colour mapping

Each lead status has exactly one badge treatment. No variation.

Status	Light bg	Light text	Dark bg	Dark text
New	#F4F4F5	#52525B	#27272A	#A1A1AA
Contacted	#FFFBEB	#B45309	#78350F @ 30%	#FBBF24
Converted	#F0FDF4	#15803D	#14532D @ 30%	#4ADE80
Lost	#FEF2F2	#B91C1C	#7F1D1D @ 30%	#F87171

3.4 Rules

- **Contrast minimum:** 4.5:1 for body text, 3:1 for text ≥ 18 px or UI elements. Verify both themes.
- **No colour conveys meaning alone.** Overdue follow-ups get a coloured dot *and* the text "Overdue". Status badges get a colour *and* a label.
- **The accent appears at most twice per screen.** Usually once: the primary action. Active navigation counts as one instance.
- **Never use a status colour for a non-status purpose.** `success` is for converted, not for "save" buttons.

4. Typography

4.1 Family

Primary: Geist Sans (fallback: system-ui, -apple-system, Segoe UI, sans-serif)

Numeric/monospace: Geist Mono (fallback: ui-monospace, SFMono-Regular, monospace)

Geist is chosen for legibility at small sizes, distinctness from the default Inter look, and a slightly technical character appropriate to a data tool. It is free and open source.

Do not use Inter. It is the default of every AI-generated design and will make the app look like every other admin panel.

4.2 Scale

Token	Size	Line height	Weight	Usage
text-2xs	11px	16px	500	Uppercase labels, badge text
text-xs	12px	16px	400	Metadata, timestamps, helper text
text-sm	13px	20px	400	Table cells, dense UI
text-base	14px	20px	400	Body, inputs, buttons
text-md	16px	24px	500	Section headers, emphasised body
text-lg	18px	28px	600	Card titles
text-xl	22px	28px	600	Page titles
text-2xl	28px	36px	600	Reserved — empty states, login title

4.3 Weights

Only three weights in use: **400** (regular), **500** (medium), **600** (semibold). No bold (700), no light (300).

4.4 Rules

- Letter-spacing:** 0 for body. -0.01em for sizes ≥18px. 0.05em for uppercase labels.

- **Numbers in data contexts:** apply `font-variant-numeric: tabular-nums`. This includes counts, dates, monetary values, IDs, and table columns.
- **Line length:** maximum 70 characters for body text. Long paragraphs in modals or empty states should wrap.
- **No text transform other than uppercase labels and badges.** No small-caps headings.
- **No text shadows, no outlined text, no gradient text.**

5. Spacing

Base unit: **4px**. Use only the values below.

Token	Value	Typical usage
space-1	4px	Icon-to-label gap, badge padding
space-2	8px	Inline gaps, tight padding
space-3	12px	Input padding horizontal, small gaps
space-4	16px	Card padding (mobile), section gaps
space-5	20px	Card padding (desktop)
space-6	24px	Section spacing, modal padding
space-8	32px	Page padding (desktop), large section gaps
space-12	48px	Between major page regions
space-16	64px	Reserved — login page vertical rhythm

Rule: never invent a spacing value. If 20px doesn't fit, use 16px or 24px.

6. Border Radius

Token	Value	Usage
radius-sm	4px	Inputs, small buttons, badges (non-pill)

Token	Value	Usage
radius-md	6px	Buttons, inputs (default), dropdowns
radius-lg	8px	Cards, panels
radius-xl	12px	Modals, large panels
radius-full	9999px	Pills, avatars, status dots

Maximum on rectangles: 12px. No 16, no 20, no 24. Pill badges are `radius-full` but only because they're short and wide.

7. Elevation

Shadows are used only for elements that genuinely float above the page.

Token	Value	Usage
shadow-none	—	Cards, inputs, buttons, table rows
shadow-sm	0 1px 2px rgba(0,0,0,0.05)	Dropdown menus
shadow-md	0 4px 12px rgba(0,0,0,0.08)	Modals, popovers
shadow-lg	0 8px 24px rgba(0,0,0,0.12)	Toasts (only)

In dark mode, shadows are nearly invisible. Modals and dropdowns get an additional `1px` border using `border-default` to define their edges.

8. Components

Every component below specifies exact values. Use these values, not approximations.

8.1 Button

Three variants: **primary**, **secondary**, **ghost**. Three sizes: **sm**, **md**, **lg**.

Property	sm	md	lg
Height	32px	36px	44px
Padding-x	12px	16px	20px
Font size	13px	14px	14px
Font weight	500	500	500
Radius	radius-md	radius-md	radius-md
Icon size	14px	16px	18px
Icon gap	6px	8px	8px

Primary

- Background: accent
- Text: #FFFFFF
- Hover: accent-hover
- Active: accent-hover, no additional transform
- Focus: 2px solid ring in accent with 2px offset
- Disabled: 40% opacity, cursor: not-allowed
- **No shadow, no gradient, no transform on hover.**

Secondary

- Background: bg-surface
- Border: 1px solid border-default
- Text: text-primary
- Hover: bg-subtle
- Active: bg-muted

Ghost

- Background: transparent
- Text: text-secondary
- Hover: bg-subtle, text text-primary
- Used for tertiary actions and icon-only buttons.

Destructive

- Same dimensions as primary.

- Background: `danger`, text white. Used only for confirmed deletes inside modals.

8.2 Input

Property	Value
Height	36px
Padding-x	12px
Font size	14px
Radius	<code>radius-md</code>
Background	<code>bg-surface</code>
Border	<code>1px solid border-default</code>
Placeholder	<code>text-tertiary</code>
Focus	<code>border accent + 3px ring in accent @ 15% opacity</code>
Error	<code>border danger + helper text below in danger , 12px</code>
Disabled	<code>background bg-subtle , text text-tertiary</code>

Label above the input. 12px, `text-secondary`, weight 500, `margin-bottom: 6px`. Required fields are marked with a `*` in `danger`.

Helper text below the input. 12px, `text-tertiary`. Replaced by an error message in `danger` when validation fails.

Textarea uses the same tokens, `min-height: 96px`, `padding: 10px 12px`, `resize: vertical`.

8.3 Card

Property	Value
Background	<code>bg-surface</code>
Border	<code>1px solid border-default</code>
Radius	<code>radius-lg</code>

Property	Value
Padding	16px mobile, 20px desktop
Shadow	none

The border alone defines the card. If a card needs to stand out, add a subtle accent border on the left edge (3px solid `accent`), not a shadow.

8.4 Status badge

Property	Value
Height	22px
Padding-x	8px
Font size	12px
Font weight	500
Radius	<code>radius-full</code>
Text transform	none
Border	none

Background and text colours from the status table in §3.3. The label is always the status name in title case: "New", "Contacted", "Converted", "Lost". No icon inside the badge.

8.5 Table

Property	Value
Row height	52px
Cell padding-x	16px
Row border	<code>1px solid border-default</code> (bottom only, all rows except last)
Header font	11px uppercase, weight 500, <code>text-secondary</code> , letter-spacing 0.05em

Property	Value
Cell font	13px, text-primary
Row hover	bg-subtle
Selected row	bg-muted
Zebra striping	never

Sort indicators: 14px chevron, text-tertiary, becomes text-primary when active.

8.6 Navigation

Top bar only. No sidebar. Height: 56px. Border-bottom: 1px solid border-default. Background: bg-surface. Sticky on scroll.

Left: wordmark ("CRM" in 16px semibold, or the user's name). Right: primary action, theme toggle, avatar menu.

Active nav item: text text-primary, 2px underline in accent below the label. No background fill, no pill.

8.7 Modal

Property	Value
Width	480px max, full-width minus 32px on mobile
Padding	24px
Radius	radius-xl
Shadow	shadow-md
Backdrop	rgba(0,0,0,0.4) light, rgba(0,0,0,0.6) dark
Title	18px, weight 600, left-aligned, margin-bottom: 16px
Actions	Right-aligned, secondary then primary, gap: 8px

No centred text. No large illustrations at the top. No close "x" floating in the corner without a label. Actions are text buttons at the bottom right.

8.8 Toast

Bottom-right on desktop, bottom-centre on mobile. Max width 360px. Padding 12px 16px. Radius `radius-lg`. Shadow `shadow-lg`. Auto-dismiss after 4 seconds. Manual dismiss via a 14px close icon on the right.

Variants: success (left border 3px `success`), error (`danger`), info (`text-secondary`). Icon 16px on the left, label 14px `text-primary`.

8.9 Empty state

No illustration. A short line of text, `text-secondary`, 14px, centred, with an optional primary action below. Example:

No leads yet. Leads submitted through your contact form will appear here. [Add lead manually]

Maximum 3 lines. No icon, no illustration, no large heading.

9. Layout

9.1 Breakpoints

Name	Min width	Layout
Mobile	0	Single column, top bar, cards
Tablet	768px	Two columns where useful, table for leads
Desktop	1024px	Max content width 1200px, centred

9.2 Page structure

Every authenticated page follows the same structure:

Top bar (56px, sticky)	
Page content, max-width 1200px, centred, padding 16px (mobile) / 32px (desktop)	

- **Page title** at 22px semibold, with an optional secondary action button on the right, aligned to the baseline.
- **Filter row** below the title if applicable: search input on the left (max-width 320px), filter chips or select on the right.
- **Content** with `margin-top: 24px`.

9.3 Vertical rhythm

- Between page title and filter row: 20px
- Between filter row and content: 24px
- Between list items (cards on mobile): 8px
- Between form fields: 16px
- Between form sections: 32px

10. Motion

Token	Duration	Easing	Usage
<code>motion-fast</code>	100ms	<code>cubic-bezier(0.4, 0, 0.2, 1)</code>	Hover, focus, colour transitions
<code>motion-base</code>	150ms	<code>cubic-bezier(0.4, 0, 0.2, 1)</code>	Standard transitions
<code>motion-slow</code>	250ms	<code>cubic-bezier(0.4, 0, 0.2, 1)</code>	Modals, dropdowns, larger movements

Rules

- Only `opacity` and `transform` are animated. Never `width`, `height`, `top`, or `left`.
- No bouncy easing. No `cubic-bezier` with values above 1.
- No looping animations. No pulses, no shimmers on anything except loading skeletons.
- Skeleton shimmer: linear gradient moving left-to-right, 1.5s loop, 30% opacity. This is the only permitted looping animation.
- Respect `prefers-reduced-motion`. When set, all durations become 0ms.

11. Iconography

Library: Lucide. Consistent stroke-width of 1.5. Sizes: 14px (inline with 13px text), 16px (standard), 20px (in buttons of lg size or standalone).

Rules

- Icons are always paired with a text label, except in icon-only buttons (theme toggle, close, avatar menu) which must have an `aria-label`.
 - Icons inherit text colour. Never give an icon a colour its adjacent label doesn't have.
 - No filled icons. Lucide's stroke style only.
 - No icons in status badges, table headers (except sort indicators), or body copy.
 - No emoji, anywhere.
-

12. Accessibility

These are enforced, not aspirational.

- **Contrast:** 4.5:1 for text under 18px, 3:1 for text 18px+ and UI components. Test both themes.
 - **Focus:** every interactive element has a visible focus ring (2px `accent`, 2px `offset`). Never `outline: none` without a replacement.
 - **Touch targets:** minimum 44 × 44px. On mobile, buttons and icon actions get extra padding if their visual size is smaller.
 - **Labels:** every input has an associated `<label>`. Placeholder is not a label.
 - **Keyboard:** every action is reachable and operable by keyboard. Tab order matches visual order. Modals trap focus and restore it on close.
 - **Motion:** `prefers-reduced-motion: reduce` disables all non-essential transitions.
 - **Colour independence:** no state is communicated by colour alone. Overdue is a dot *and* the word "Overdue". Status is a colour *and* the label.
-

13. Copy

Voice: direct, plain, unadorned. No exclamation marks. No emoji. No "Oops!", no "Whoops!", no "Let's get started!". No exclamation points in success messages.

Context	Do	Don't
Success toast	"Lead created."	"Awesome! Your lead was created! 🎉"
Error toast	"Couldn't save changes. Try again."	"Oops! Something went wrong 😞"
Empty list	"No leads yet."	"Nothing to see here — time to add your first lead!"
Delete confirmation	"Delete this lead? This also removes its notes and activity. This can't be undone."	"Are you sure you want to delete? This action is irreversible!"
Loading	"Loading leads..."	"Just a moment while we fetch your leads!"

Title case for buttons and page titles. Sentence case for everything else. No ALL CAPS except short labels and table headers.

14. AI Generation Rules

When generating any UI in this project, whether by hand or by prompting an AI, the following must be respected:

1. **Use only tokens from this document.** If a value is needed that isn't listed, add it here first.
2. **Never produce a gradient, glassmorphism, or a purple element.** These are hard exclusions.
3. **Never use shadows on cards, inputs, or buttons.** Only modals, dropdowns, popovers, and toasts.
4. **Never use an illustration or decorative graphic.** Icons only, from Lucide.
5. **Never use emoji as a UI element.**
6. **Never use centered text** except in empty states and the login screen.
7. **Never invent a component that isn't specified here.** If a new component is required, specify it in §8 before implementing.
8. **Never use Inter.** Geist Sans is the family.
9. **Never add motion** beyond the durations in §10.
10. **Never exceed 12px radius** on rectangles.

Any generated UI that breaks these rules is a defect, not a style difference.

15. Reference — token cheat sheet

For copy-paste into Tailwind config or CSS variables.

COLOURS (light)

bg-canvas	#FAFAFA
bg-surface	#FFFFFF
bg-subtle	#F4F4F5
bg-muted	#E4E4E7
border-default	#E4E4E7
border-strong	#A1A1AA
text-primary	#18181B
text-secondary	#52525B
text-tertiary	#71717A
accent	#1D4ED8
accent-hover	#1E40AF
accent-subtle-bg	#EFF6FF
success	#15803D
success-subtle-bg	#F0FDF4
warning	#B45309
warning-subtle-bg	#FFFBEA
danger	#B91C1C
danger-subtle-bg	#FEE2E2
neutral-subtle-bg	#F4F4F5

COLOURS (dark)

bg-canvas	#09090B
bg-surface	#18181B
bg-subtle	#27272A
bg-muted	#3F3F46
border-default	#27272A
border-strong	#52525B
text-primary	#FAFAFA
text-secondary	#A1A1AA
text-tertiary	#71717A
accent	#3B82F6
accent-hover	#60A5FA

SPACING

```
1  4px  2  8px  3 12px  4 16px  5 20px
6 24px  8 32px 12 48px 16 64px

RADIUS
sm 4px  md 6px  lg 8px  xl 12px  full 9999px

TYPE
2xs 11/16/500  xs 12/16/400  sm 13/20/400
base 14/20/400  md 16/24/500  lg 18/28/600
xl 22/28/600  2xl 28/36/600
```

End of Brand & Style Guide.

This is deliberately prescriptive. The way to stop AI from producing generic output is not to describe a vibe — it's to forbid specific defaults and give exact values for everything else. Sections 2 and 14 are the load-bearing ones: they name the clichés explicitly so an AI tool (or a person) can't drift into them by accident.

If you want, next I can convert §15 into an actual `tailwind.config.js` and a `tokens.css` so the tokens are code, not documentation.